

Figure 4.10 *Ghazni, minaret of Mas'ud III (1099–1115), with citadel in background. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

have been the expression of the royal patrons' preference: the initial verses of Surat al-Fath (Q. XLVIII) as the principal inscriptions on the *madrasa*'s main façade along the complex's southern perimeter (Figure 4.1). Verses from this Sura were extremely rare in monumental epigraphy anywhere in the Islamic world, with their first documented occurrence in the eastern Islamic lands on the *minar* of Mas'ud III (r. AH 492–509/1099–1115 CE) at Ghazna (Figures 4.10 and 4.11).[61] This memorable and towering architectural work had been among the structures that escaped Sultan 'Ala' al-Din Husain's sacking of the city after his defeat of Bahram Shah in AH 544–45/1150 CE – the occasion that earned him the sobriquet *Jahan-suz* (cf. esp. Chapter 1) – only about fifteen years before the foundation of Shah-i Mashhad.[62]

Pinder-Wilson convincingly proposed that the Ghazna *minar*'s inscriptional program had been inspired by the resumption of successful campaigns to northern India during the reign of Mas'ud III in the early twelfth century, after a lapse of about a half-century during which the Ghaznavid